

Working at Home, But Treated Unfairly -- Millions of Women Speak Up

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Have you ever helped make something at home, like a craft, and thought, "I should get paid for this"? Millions of people around the world do exactly that but they don't get fair pay or rights. They're called **home-based workers**, and most are women. In a hot, crowded neighborhood in New Delhi, India, Shehnaz Bano stitches leather jacket pieces on her floor. She works for hours on each piece but gets only 100 rupees about \$1. "If I did the same work in a factory, I'd be paid more," she says. "Just because I work from home, I don't get equal pay or rights." Thirty years ago today, on June 20, 1996, a United Nations group called the International Labour Organization (ILO) created a rule **Convention 177** to fix this. It says **home-based workers** should be treated the same as other workers. But only 13 countries have signed on, and none in **South Asia**, where most of these workers live. **Activists** say that's because women's work at home is often seen as just "housework," not real work. The ILO says we need to make these workers visible, give them fair pay, safety, and a stronger voice. Shehnaz and 260 million others are still waiting.

Word Treasure

home-based workers -- People who do jobs like sewing or crafting from their own homes instead of going to a factory or office.

International Labour Organization (ILO) -- A group inside the United Nations that makes rules to protect workers all around the world.

Convention 177 -- A special rule made by the ILO in 1996 that says home-based workers should have the same rights as other workers.

South Asia -- A part of the world that includes countries like India, Pakistan, and Bangladesh, where many people work from home.

rupees -- The type of money used in India, worth very little compared to a U.S. dollar.

activists -- People who fight for change by speaking out, organizing, and trying to fix unfair situations.

Background you need

The United Nations (UN) is an organization where countries work together on big problems; the International Labour Organization (ILO) is a UN group that focuses on workers' rights.

South Asia, which includes countries like India, Pakistan, and Bangladesh, has a huge number of people who work from home because factories are far away or they cannot leave the house.

Women's work at home--like sewing, making crafts, or packaging--is often invisible and not counted as real jobs, so they don't get the same protections as factory workers.

Break it down

WHO: Home-based workers like Shehnaz Bano, the ILO, and activists.

WHAT: Millions of home-based workers, mostly women, are paid unfairly and lack rights, though Convention 177 says they should be treated equally.

WHERE: New Delhi, India, and across South Asia.

WHY: Because work done at home is often seen as just housework, so governments don't enforce fair pay and safety rules.

Why it matters

When you see things you buy--like toys or clothes--remember that someone might have made them at home for very low pay, and fair rules can help those workers get treated better.

Test what you remember

1. What is the name for people like Shehnaz Bano who work at home?
 - (A) factory workers
 - (B) home-based workers
 - (C) office workers
 - (D) farm workers
2. How much money does Shehnaz get for each leather jacket piece she sews?
 - (A) 100 rupees
 - (B) 200 rupees
 - (C) 50 rupees
 - (D) 100 dollars
3. What is the name of the United Nations group that made Convention 177?
 - (A) World Health Organization
 - (B) International Labour Organization
 - (C) UNICEF
 - (D) World Trade Organization
4. About how many people around the world are home-based workers?
 - (A) 100 million
 - (B) 150 million
 - (C) 260 million
 - (D) 50 million
5. In which region do most of these workers live?
 - (A) Europe
 - (B) South Asia
 - (C) North America
 - (D) Australia
6. How many countries have signed Convention 177 so far?
 - (A) 5
 - (B) 13
 - (C) 30
 - (D) 100

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: B 4: C 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **Home-based workers:** They want fair pay, rest days, and safety protections just like workers in factories. Many feel invisible and undervalued even though they work hard.
2. **Employers and some governments:** They may not want to sign Convention 177 because it could cost more money if they have to give proper wages and benefits to home workers.
3. **The ILO and activists:** They believe making these workers visible is the first step to justice. They push for more countries to adopt the convention and change old ideas about women's work.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):